

Lalit Modi taught us what we can do with cricket, says former Rajasthan captain Sanjay Vyas



At the *Sportstar Sports Conclave - Focus Rajasthan*, held at Poornima University, former Rajasthan cricket team captain Sanjay Vyas praised administrator Lalit Modi for transforming the State's cricket structure. "I have seen many changes. When I started, Rajasthan cricket was run by the Rungtas, who managed it like a family business. Lalit Modi brought professionalism. We didn't know how to commercialise cricket until Modi showed us. He organised an exhibition match between the England team and Rajasthan players, raising Rs. 1 crore for Rajasthan cricket and increasing our DA fourfold when we requested," Vyas shared in a discussion led by *Sportstar's* senior assistant editor, Shayan Acharya.

Vyas attributed Rajasthan's back-to-back Ranji Trophy wins in 2010/11 and 2011/12 to Modi's administration. "We needed a coach, and he wanted only the best. He appointed Greg Chappell and set up a system. By 2009, a pool of fast bowlers was established, leading to our Ranji victories," he said.

Gagan Khoda, former India international and Rajasthan player, highlighted the State's recent surge in talent. "Self-belief has grown, especially with the IPL's influence. Sharing dressing rooms with top players has boosted confidence and mental toughness. Players like Rahul Chahar, Khaleel Ahmed, and Ravi Bishnoi have represented India. Now, talent is emerging

(L-R) Gagan Khoda, Sanjay Vyas and Rajeev Khanna in conversation with Sportstar senior assistant editor Shayan Acharya during the Sportstar Sports Conclave — Focus Rajasthan at the Poornima University. R. V. MOORTHY

from all districts, not just major cities like Jaipur," Khoda noted.

Despite this, Rajasthan has struggled to produce Test players, with Pankaj Singh being the last to earn a Test cap. Khoda stressed the importance of better infrastructure. "We need grounds accessible to all, including remote districts, which report to main centres like Jaipur. Diverse playing conditions are essential; we mainly played at the KL Saini ground, with limited matches at the Sawai Mansingh Stadium. More exposure to different pitches is needed," Khoda added.

Rajasthan Royals vice president Rajeev Khanna announced a significant step forward: "We have signed an MoU with the Rajasthan government for a Rs. 10,000 crore multi-sport hub. It will be a complete sports city."

Khanna also shared efforts to develop women's cricket. "We recently held a girls' talent hunt involving 1,500 schools from districts like Bikaner. Though we couldn't join the Women's Premier League, we aim to create a talent pool for state and WPL teams," he said.

